

ABITURPRÜFUNG 2025

zum Erwerb der fachgebundenen/allgemeinen Hochschulreife
an Fachoberschulen und Berufsoberschulen

ENGLISCH

Montag, 2. Juni 2025

READING COMPREHENSION TEXTS

Prüfungsbeginn: 09:00 Uhr

Diese Prüfung besteht aus zwei Teilen:

READING: Tasks I - III (9:00 bis 10:30 Uhr)

Organisatorische Pause

WRITING: Mediation D-E und Material-Based Writing (90 Minuten)

Im **READING**-Teil werden Texte und Aufgaben in zwei getrennten Geheften vorgelegt.

Die Aufgaben (**TASKS**) liegen in zwei Varianten (**V1** und **V2**) vor.

Diese sind gemischt auszugeben.

Alle Lösungen sind von den Prüflingen im Aufgabengeheft einzutragen.

In der Pause werden die Text- und Aufgabengehefte von den Arbeitsplätzen der Schüler entfernt.

Der **WRITING**-Teil wird erst nach der organisatorischen Pause ausgegeben.

Hilfsmittel: Ein einsprachiges Wörterbuch (ggf. auch inkl. Writing Tutor)

Reading Text I: Lessons in Chemistry

The following text is an excerpt from the novel "Lessons in Chemistry" by Bonnie Garmus.

Chapter 1 - November, 1961

Back in 1961, when women wore shirtwaist dresses and joined garden clubs and drove legions of children around in seatbelt-less cars without giving it a second thought; back before anyone knew there'd even be a 60s movement, much less one that its participants would spend the next sixty years chronicling; back when the big wars were over and the secret wars had just begun and people were starting to think fresh and believe everything was possible, the thirty-year-old mother of Madeline Zott rose before dawn every morning and felt certain of just one thing: her life was over. Despite that certainty, she made her way to the lab to pack her daughter's lunch.

"Fuel for learning," Elizabeth Zott wrote on a small slip of paper before tucking it into her daughter's lunchbox. Then she paused, her pencil in mid-air, as if reconsidering. "Play sports at recess but do not automatically let the boys win," she wrote on another slip. Then she paused again, tapping her pencil against the table. "It **GAP 1**," she wrote on a third. "Most people are awful." She placed the last two on top.

Most young children can't read, and if they can, it's mostly words like 'dog' and 'go.' But Madeline had been reading since age three and, now, at age five, was already through most of Charles Dickens. **Madeline was that kind of child** — the kind who could hum a Bach concerto, but couldn't tie her own shoes; who could explain the earth's rotation, but stumbled at tic-tac-toe. And that was the problem. Because while musical prodigies are always celebrated, early readers aren't. And that's because early readers are only good at something others will eventually be good at, too. So being first isn't special — it's just annoying.

Madeline understood this. That's why she made it a point each morning — after her mother had left and while her babysitter neighbor, Harriet, was busy — to extract the notes from the lunchbox, read them, then store them with all the other notes which she kept in a shoebox in the back of her closet. Once at school she pretended to be like all the other kids. To Madeline, fitting in mattered more than anything. And **GAP 2**: her mother had never fit in and look what happened to her.

It was there, in the southern Californian town of Commons, where the weather was mostly warm, but not too warm, and the sky was mostly blue, but not too blue, and the air was clean just because air just was back then, that she lay in her bed, eyes closed, and waited. Soon she knew there'd be a gentle kiss on her forehead, a careful tuck of covers about her shoulders, a murmuring of **GAP 3** in her ear. In another minute, she'd hear the start of a car engine, a crunch of tires as the Plymouth backed down the drive, a clunky shift from reverse to first. And then her permanently depressed mother would set off for the television studio where she would don an

apron and walk out onto a set. The show was called Supper at Six, and Elizabeth Zott was its indisputable star.

35 Chapter 2 – Amanda and Walter Pine

Once a research chemist, Elizabeth Zott was a woman with flawless skin and an unmistakable demeanor of someone who was not average and never would be. She was, as all good stars are, discovered. Although in Elizabeth's case, there was no malt shop, no accidental bench sighting, no lucky introduction. Instead, it was theft — specifically food theft — that led to her discovery.

40 The story was simple: a child named Amanda Pine, who enjoyed food in a way some therapists consider significant, was eating Madeline's lunch. This was because Madeline's lunch was not average. While all the other children gummed their peanut butter and jelly sandwiches, Madeline opened her lunch box to find a thick slice of leftover lasagna, a side helping of buttery zucchini, an exotic kiwi cut into quarters, five pearly round cherry tomatoes, a tiny Morton salt shaker, two
45 still-warm chocolate chip cookies, and a red plaid thermos full of ice-cold milk. These contents were why everyone wanted Madeline's lunch, Madeline included. But Madeline offered it to Amanda because **GAP 4**, but also because Amanda was the only one in the entire school who didn't make fun of the odd child Madeline already knew she was.

It wasn't until Elizabeth noticed that Madeline's clothes began to hang on her bony frame like
50 bad drapes that she began to wonder what was going on. According to her calculations, Madeline's daily intake was exactly what her daughter required for optimal development making weight loss scientifically inconceivable. A growth spurt, then? No. She'd accounted for growth in her calculations. Early onset food disorder? Not likely. Madeline ate like a horse at dinner. Leukemia? Definitely not. Elizabeth wasn't an alarmist — she wasn't the type who lay awake at
55 night imagining her daughter was plagued by incurable disease. As a scientist, she always sought a sensible explanation, and the moment she met Amanda Pine, her little lips stained a Pomodoro-sauce red, she knew she'd found it.

"Mr. Pine," Elizabeth said, sweeping into the local television studio and past a secretary on a Wednesday afternoon, "I've been calling you for three days, and not once have you managed the
60 courtesy of a return call. My name is Elizabeth Zott. I am Madeline Zott's mother — our children attend Woody Elementary together — and I'm here to tell you that your daughter is offering my daughter **GAP 5**." And because he looked confused, she added, "your daughter is eating my daughter's lunch." "L-lunch?" Walter Pine managed, as he took in the woman who stood resplendent before him, her white lab coat casting an aura of holy light save for one detail: the
65 initials "E.Z." emblazoned in red just above the pocket. "Your daughter, Amanda," Elizabeth charged again, "eats my daughter's lunch. Apparently, it's been going on for months."

Walter could only stare. Tall and angular, with hair the color of burnt buttered toast pulled back and secured with a pencil, she stood, hands on hips, her lips unapologetically red, her skin luminous, her nose straight. She looked down at him like a battlefield medic assessing whether

70 or not he was worth saving. “And the fact that she pretends to be Madeline’s friend to get her lunch,” she continued, “**GAP 6**.”

“Who—who are you again?” stammered Walter.

“Elizabeth Zott!” she barked back. “Madeline Zott’s mother!”

75 Walter nodded, trying to understand. As a long-time producer of afternoon television, he knew drama. But this? He continued to stare. She was stunning. He was literally stunned by her. Was she auditioning for something?

“I’m sorry,” he finally said. “But all the nurse roles have been cast.”

“I beg your pardon?” she snapped.

There was a long pause.

Bonnie Garmus, *Lessons in Chemistry*, New York, 2022.

(1157 words; abridged and adapted)

Reading Text II:

English still rules the world, but that's not necessarily OK.

(A) Anyone spending their holidays on the European mainland will likely have observed that it is quite common to meet staff in shops and hotels who can hold a conversation in English, and to read signs and menus in the language. This fact should come as no surprise, and it is no accident: the spread of English skills in Europe is largely the result of educational policies that have intensively promoted its teaching in public schools over the past decades.

(B) The reasons are diverse and well known. English is a major language of culture, and it is the third most spoken language in the world as a native language, after Chinese and Spanish. Native speakers of English number about 373m (roughly 5% of the world population), mostly concentrated in six advanced industrialised democracies (Australia, Canada, Ireland, New Zealand, the UK and the US), which together produce 33% of the world's gross domestic product in nominal terms. As a legacy of the British Empire, English is an official or co-official language in many countries of the world, mainly in Africa.

(C) The communication value of English is therefore high, and so is the interest in learning it. Many people use English as a second or foreign language. Precise estimates are risky but taken together, native and non-native speakers in the world total between 1 billion and 1.5 billion, depending on the definition of "speaker". This amounts to 12-19% of the global population. Proficiency levels, however, are very uneven.

(D) The emergence of English as the predominant (though not exclusive) international language is seen by many as a positive phenomenon with several practical advantages and no downside. However, it also raises problems that are slowly beginning to be understood and studied. The most important challenge is that of "linguistic justice". A common language is a bit like a telephone network: the more people know a language, the more useful it becomes to communicate. The question of fairness arises because individuals face very different costs to access the network and are on an unequal footing when using it. Those who learn English as a second language incur learning costs, while native speakers can communicate with all network members without incurring such costs. It's like getting the latest smartphone model and sim card with unlimited data for free.

(E) François Grin, of the University of Geneva, estimates that western European countries spend between 5% and 15% of their education budget on foreign language teaching. In the EU, most of these resources go to the teaching of a single language, English. With the obvious exception of Ireland, English as a foreign language is taught in schools in all EU member states, usually as a compulsory subject. In English-speaking countries, by contrast, foreign language teaching has long been in decline because younger generations feel less need to learn other people's languages, turning to other subjects instead. This trend translates into considerable savings for the education systems of English-speaking countries.

(F) A second type of inequality relates to the use of a common language. In most professional contexts, a person is more effective and persuasive when using their native language. This inequality is difficult, but not impossible, to quantify. In scientific research, English is often required for publishing in international journals and obtaining research funding. A team led by Tatsuya Amano at the University of Queensland recently published a study of 900 researchers in environmental sciences revealing that non-native English-speaking researchers require as much as twice the time needed by native speakers to read, write or review publications in English. When submitting papers for publication, non-native speakers are about 2.5 times more likely to have their work rejected for linguistic reasons. So, even with equal or greater technical competence, they may have fewer career opportunities.

(G) It is certainly easier to identify a problem than to find solutions, particularly when it comes to global issues. However, some compensatory measures may help reduce global linguistic injustice. Philippe Van Parijs, of the University of Louvain, has, somewhat provocatively, proposed a linguistic tax on English-speaking countries to compensate for the costs of teaching English in other countries. This would involve establishing a global tax on countries where the majority of the population speaks English as a native language and distributing the revenue to countries where English is taught in schools as a foreign language.

(H) Yet other forms of indirect compensation could be considered; for example, a partial weakening of industrial property rights, such as patents. The maximum duration of the legal protection of patents is 20 years. This duration could be shortened by a few years when businesses based in an English-speaking country register a patent in a non-English-speaking country. This would mean that these patents could be commercially exploited without a license more quickly than patents belonging to inventors based in other countries. The World Intellectual Property Organization could promote a reform of rules in this direction.

(I) Of course, the problem of linguistic justice is not confined to English. The very same problem would arise if the dominant language of global communication were another, such as Spanish or French (but not a neutral language such as Esperanto). But right now, English is the predominant international language. For many this is a blessing, but should we not also think of those for whom it is a cause for concern?

Reading Text III:

The death of American exceptionalism

(A) The prevalence of positive illusions is one of the most well-established findings in psychology. Most people have an exaggerated view of their own abilities and expect that more good things—and fewer bad things—will happen to them than is likely. Despite being unrealistic, such beliefs have benefits: Overly positive people are happier, cope better with adversity, and think they have more control over their life. Believing that things are a little better than they actually are may be necessary for robust mental health.

(B) In a similar way, many citizens hold overly positive, but possibly necessary, beliefs about their country. A sense of national pride can foster community and bring people together, and it's often a sign of a thriving democracy. In the United States, one source of patriotism is American exceptionalism—the idea that the U.S. is a unique, and uniquely superior, nation. With its origin as a democracy in a world of kingdoms and its emphasis on freedom and opportunity, this narrative goes, the American system is out of the ordinary.

(C) Among the young, that belief is rapidly dying. Since 1976, a large nationally representative survey has asked U.S. high-school seniors, 17 and 18 years old, whether they agree that “Despite its many faults, our system of doing things is still the best in the world”: a fairly succinct summary of American exceptionalism. In the early 1980s, 67 percent of high-school seniors agreed that the U.S. system was the best. By 2022, only 27 percent did. Thus, only one out of four American teens now agrees that their country is exceptional. (...)

(D) Support for the idea is now particularly unpopular among liberal teens. As recently as the late 1990s, a majority had agreed that the U.S. system was the best. By 2021–22, that had shrunk to 14 percent—only one out of seven. (...) Even the belief that the founding of the United States was a positive development seems to be on the way out: A recent poll conducted by the Democracy Fund asked Americans if the Founders are “better described as villains” or “as heroes.” Four out of 10 Gen Zers chose “villains,” compared with only one in 10 Boomers. If your country's Founders are the bad guys instead of the good guys, it becomes much harder to believe that its system is the best in the world—or even worth defending. (...)

(E) Dour views of the nation's status and possibilities may shape its future. **Gen Z may be disillusioned, but it is not, by and large, nihilistic:** Today's young adults are also more interested in taking action than previous generations. From 2014 to 2021–22, an increasing number of high-school seniors agreed that protesting and voting could have “a major impact on how things are run in this country.” Voter turnout among young adults has been higher among Gen Z than previous generations at the same age, and political protests appear to have become more frequent in the eight or so years since Gen Z arrived on college campuses.

(F) That, of course, could yield positive changes. One of the most important American ideals, arguably, is that the American project is unfinished, and that society can be made better, generation by generation. Throughout U.S. history, discontent and even righteous anger have often been important correctives to overly broad or unthinking sentiments about the country's

goodness, which, when unchallenged, can perpetuate injustices. But many of Gen Z's members seem convinced that radical change is necessary—to the model of government, to the economy, to the culture. In a 2020 poll, three out of four American Gen Zers—more than any other generation—agreed that “significant changes” were needed to the government’s “fundamental design and structure.” (...)

(G) Why has Gen Z turned so definitively toward disillusionment and away from seeing their country as superior? One reason may be their mental health: Twice as many teens and young adults are depressed than in the early 2010s. This is a tragedy—and it’s likely to have wide-reaching effects. Depression isn’t just about emotions; it’s also about cognition. By definition, depressed people see the world in a more negative light. They are less likely to see the positive, including in their country. Increases in depression are larger among liberals, consistent with the larger decline in their belief in American exceptionalism.

(H) Changes in news consumption may also play a part. When newspapers were read on paper, all of the news—positive and negative—was printed together. Now negative news is king. Negative articles are almost twice as likely to be shared on social media as positive articles. Social-media algorithms push angry and divisive content. With Gen Z getting most of its information online, it is viewing the country through a negatively skewed funhouse mirror.

(J) A third reason may lie in the shifts in high-school American-history curricula. Some—typically liberal—states now spend more time than they once did on the more deplorable facts of the nation’s history, such as the internment of Japanese Americans during World War II, the massacre of Native Americans, and the Founders’ ownership of slaves. That coverage lays out facts students need to know, but, especially if these events are emphasized more than the country’s more noble endeavors, it may also undermine feelings of national pride.

(K) Finally, Gen Z’s facility with social media may itself be coloring the generation’s views. Gen Z has learned that making a problem look as big and awful as possible is a highly effective way of getting traction on social media. Many problems are often portrayed as profound and systemic, fixable only by fundamental rethinks and institutional purges. It makes everything seem worse than it is.

(L) My worry (...) is that **these various forces—and the pessimism they have generated —could move Gen Z to change systems that are not necessarily broken.** That’s especially relevant as this generation comes of age and rises toward political power. Despite the common perception that the system is “rigged” and young people will never attain the wealth Boomers did, for instance, the Federal Reserve of St. Louis recently found that Millennial and Gen Z young adults actually have 25 percent more wealth than Boomers did at the same age. Inflation-adjusted median incomes for American young adults are at all-time highs, and poverty rates for children and younger adults are lower than they were in the early 2000s. The social-media-driven negativity machine may have prevented Gen Z—and all of us—from seeing the good news.